

Hands in Clay

A beginners' wheel afternoon - handout for participants

Taught by Margaret Farmer

At the collective

One afternoon, 6 people

Welcome. This is one afternoon, three hours, six pairs of hands. You will not master the wheel today. Nobody does. What you will get is the feel of centred clay, one small bowl to keep, and an honest idea of how slow and how good this craft is. Tea at the halfway point. Aprons by the door.

The afternoon

Time	What we do
First 30 min	Wedging. Getting the air out and the clay even. Boring and the most important thing.
Next 45 min	Centring. The whole game. Wet hands, slow wheel, lean in. You will fight it. Let the clay win first.
Tea	A proper break. Look at some finished pots, feel the weight of a fired bowl.
75 min	Opening and pulling one small bowl each. I help hands-on. We keep the best one each.
Last 20 min	Trimming talk and what happens next, drying, bisque, glaze, the long wait for the kiln.

To take home

- Your bowl needs two weeks to dry, then bisque, then glaze, then the glaze firing. I will fire them with the next load and you collect in about a month.
- Clay is patient and so must you be. The potters you admire have thrown thousands of bad bowls. So have I.
- If this afternoon catches you, the collective runs longer courses. Ask me, or ask Mika.

Fee covers clay, firing, and your bowl. Workshops like this are a small second income for me and a way to pass on what was passed to me in Shigaraki. The young-potter fund takes a share of each workshop, see the donation note.